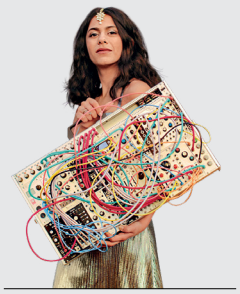
Under the Raga's Influence

New albums that take inspiration from Hindustani classical music



AROOJ AFTAB
Vulture Prince
One of 2021's best albums, Aftab's *Vulture Prince* is based almost entirely on *ragas* and old ghazals. Though she won a Grammy in the Best Global Performance category, her nomination for the Best New Artist award has become a high watermark for musicians working with Hindustani classical and folk music.

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ARUSHI JAIN
Under the Lilac Sky
Initially composed for a sunset performance at the Magnetic Fields festival in Rajasthan, *Under the Lilac Sky*, a six-track suite, reinterprets four evening *ragas*—Des, Khamaj, Kafi and Durga—for modular synthesis, elegantly weaving together ancient tradition and new-age experimentation.

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JAUBI
Nafs at Peace
Lahore quartet Jaubi team up with UK multi-instrumentalist Ed "Tenderlonious" Cawthorne and Polish composer Marek "Latarnik" Pędziwiatr to create this exquisite collection of instrumental pieces that bring *ragas* into conversation with spiritual jazz, funk and hip-hop.



COOL COLLAB Shantanu Moitra (left) and Mohit Chauhan perform during the shoot of *Songs of the River*

MUSIC

Letting the Music Flow

A new documentary shows how a cycling trip along the Ganga helped composer **Shantanu Moitra** cope with profound loss

After composing the music for the film *PK* (2014), composer and musician Shantanu Moitra felt an urge to step away for a bit. The rigours of Bollywood, as also the limitations of format impositions in music, had taken a toll. So, off he went to the Himalayas, for 100 days, with a friend. "I kept thinking: "*Kamaal ka desh hai hamaara, kamaal ke log hain* (this country and its people are spectacular). I started humming something very unlike the stuff I had done for Bollywood. All this classical music I heard as a kid—my father is from Varanasi—was, I think, in my DNA. I realised that if I travel, new music and ideas will come to me," says Moitra.

Thus began a long journey building up to *Songs of the River*, a 3,000 km expedition from Gomukh to Gangasagar, most of it on his cycle, and part of it on a boat. He has turned it into a docu-series, now streaming on Disney+Hotstar, tracking his journey along the Ganga. It was his father who first suggested a trip to the Ganga: "'Come to Banaras,' he told me. 'Or anywhere along the Ganga. You'll find some meaning in it.'" While Moitra terms himself "a lazy Bengali", his love for adventure and the great outdoors overrides those laidback instincts.

In the devastating second wave of Covid infections in India in 2021, Moitra lost his father, someone he shared a profound relationship with. "Covid and his passing propelled me with that urgency. Now I have to do this." In a way, *Songs of the River* is also a tribute to his father and the many lives lost to Covid. In the series, he carries 800 photographs of people who had died in that time, to honour them and perform ceremonies in their memory.

IN A WAY, MOITRA'S *SONGS OF THE RIVER* IS A TRIBUTE TO HIS FATHER AND THE MANY LIVES LOST TO COVID

Songs of the River becomes a way for Moitra to connect with his roots, to channel the emotions and experiences into meaningful music. Each episode features a collaboration drawing from his travels, and the river itself, as he brings in artists such as Mohit Chauhan, Maati Bani and Taba Chake, Bombay Jayashri, Sid Sriram, Ambi Subramaniam, Kaushiki Chakraborty and Rathijit Bhattacharjee along for parts of his trip. His reasons for working with them went beyond just their considerable artistic merit—from teaching music, working with autistic children, feeding stray dogs, he knew they were all good people, making a difference. In *Songs of the River*, we see Moitra work on a song with each of them, bouncing off ideas for an album.

"Movement, travel," he says, "is the best recipe for a composer. And yet, we end up doing it in closed rooms. When I'm cycling, a rhythm comes to me. A tune. It's that openness. This note won't come if you don't experience it." ■

Akhil Sood